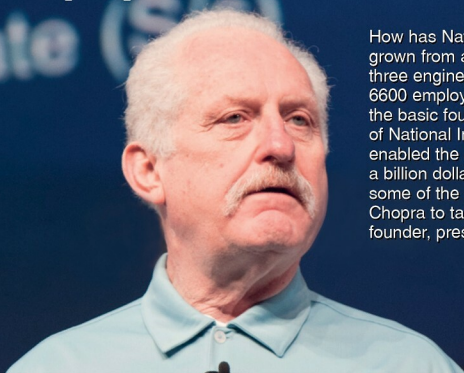


I wanted to create a company where people didn't have to leave to grow



DR JAMES TRUCHARD
FOUNDER, PRESIDENT AND CEO,
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How has National Instruments (NI) grown from an organisation run by three engineers to a company with 6600 employees worldwide? What are the basic foundations that the founder of National Instruments laid that have enabled the organisation to grow into a billion dollar enterprise? Those were some of the questions that drove Rahul Chopra to talk to Dr James Truchard, founder, president and CEO of NI

What motivated you to start NI?

Autonomy was the main idea. I was in Austin and working at the University of Texas. I had just finished my Ph.D and was working in a research lab. I wanted to stay in Austin as I loved the place, so I wanted to create a job that I liked. I realised that to achieve these goals I would have to create a good business.

Plus, I constantly saw a lot of students being forced to leave the city due to limited career options in the region. I wanted to create a company where people didn't have to leave to grow, because they had a career path. So that was one of the fundamental goals as well. To this day, that goal remains key to NI and that's why we put a lot of importance on professional growth.

In these days of frequent economic turbulences, NI has a 100-year plan! What's this plan about?

Right from the start in the 70s, we always looked at other companies and their culture, and how they operated, to pick up good ideas. It was not until we were to go public that I realised that putting our philosophy down on paper would be helpful when talking to shareholders. So in 1995, I came out with the 100-year plan, which was aimed to frame how we will make decisions.

At the 100-year level, we set the frame for our role in

the society. We talk about our philosophy of operations and how it is designed to benefit all the stakeholders.

Then if you look at the next (decade) level, you have the vision of what you are trying to do as a company. When we started, we had a pretty simple vision for creating jobs that we would enjoy and to self-finance the company. It was also the concept of automation of instrumentation that we started, then we went into the vision of what we wanted to do for virtual instrumentation. Vision for us is really a decade timeline.

The next level is the five year time-line, which gets topical, like alternative energy which is important. This term is where we start looking at how fast we can grow in the next five years and so forth.

Then at the one-year level, we look at our goals for the current year, our budgets and so forth.

The overall idea is that we should always look at the long term when we make decisions, and look at the timeline to know when these decisions need to be made and executed.

Typically, entrepreneurs find it difficult to change their role as the organisation evolves. How did you manage this transition?

That's an important aspect, and a very tough thing to